

A Remarkable Centenary: the Adventures of an Edwardian Lady Parachutist

Kenneth Hillier

Two thousand five hundred feet above Ashby-de-la-Zouch a twenty-one year old girl, having checked the small aneroid attached to her wrist, tugged on a ripping-cord. Within seconds the huge gas balloon above her, its valve sprung open, was rapidly deflating and falling earthwards. After a sudden drop of some 250 feet, the canopy of a parachute (released simultaneously from beneath the balloon) billowed open. With both hands tightly clutching a trapeze bar, and only a webbed sling as additional security, the girl gently swayed towards the ground. It was 3rd August 1908, one hundred years ago; the occasion – the Bank Holiday Fete; the girl – Miss Dolly Shepherd, the Edwardian Parachute Queen.

What was remarkable about this particular jump was that, just eight weeks earlier, Dolly had suffered concussion of the pelvis, spinal paralysis and bruising to most of her body. She had been told she would never walk again. She had become national news and was one day to feature in the *Guinness Book of Records* for 'The First Mid-Air Rescue'.

The national and local newspapers of the time had a field day. (1)

By the time of her double leap ordeal in 1908, Dolly was already a veteran parachutist. After half an hour's training and for a fee of £2 10s. she had made her first jump as a 17 year-old above the Alexandra Palace in London in 1904. She was to become a regular visitor to the Midlands, and to Coalville and Ashby-de-la-Zouch in particular. On her visit to the May Bank Holiday Fete in the Bath Grounds, Ashby in 1907, with a show audience of ten thousand visitors, she even managed to upstage Ashby Hastings Cricket Club's defeat of Leicester County by 250 runs to 99 that day. When her parachute was seen to open successfully, 'there was loud applause. Mr Jones, coachbuilder of Measham, drove in the direction of the descent, and arrived in a field near Willesley just as Miss Shepherd alighted (not far from where the descent was made last year by the lady who fell into a tree), and brought her back to the grounds'.

Parachutists' Thrilling Adventure A Terrible Ordeal Double Leap for Life From a Height of Two Miles

A Parachute descent by two young ladies at London Park Fetes last night was attended by a thrilling escape from a terrible death. The two ladies were Miss Daisy Sheppard [sic], an experienced parachutist, and Miss Louie May, and their parachutes were attached to a mammoth balloon, which, in the presence of a large crowd of spectators, made an ascent from the park during the evening. While in mid-air, however, Miss May's parachute became entangled with a rope or portion of netting, and failed to act. Meanwhile, the balloon was rapidly ascending, exceeding the height of 4,000ft., at which the descent was to have been made, and attaining an altitude of 7,000ft.

Miss May readily realised the imminent danger in which she was placed, and, as the balloon continued on its upward flight, made a desperate attempt to reach her companion on the second parachute by climbing across the balloon. To add to her plight, she herself became entangled in the netting, and was in great peril of being hurled headlong through the air. But at last she succeeded in joining Miss Sheppard, who had fortunately delayed her descent on becoming aware of her companion's difficulties. Then, hanging on to one parachute, the two girls descended.

They were discovered last night at Field, near Leigh, twelve miles from Longton. Owing to the increased weight on the parachute they had made the descent at a great speed and were, in consequence, badly shaken on reaching earth. Miss Sheppard was unable to move, but help was speedily forthcoming, and medical assistance at once procured.

Another account says: Attempts to get the entangled balloon clear occupied the time until the balloon had reached the fearful height of eleven thousand feet. Then the young lady, whose parachute was entangled, resolved upon a desperate expedient. Taking her life in her hands, she made a flying leap from her side of the balloon to her companion, who helped her on to the narrow bar. Then the two girls, with wonderful nerve, leaped from the trapeze together, and made the descent on a single parachute, which had remained in proper working order.

For a time they dropped like a stone, but while still at a great height the parachute opened and began to check their descent. Intended for the weight of one person, however, the parachute came down much quicker than the normal pace, with the result that while Miss May had the good fortune to escape unhurt, her companion, Miss Sheppard, received serious injuries.

When they reached ground the ladies were eleven miles away from their starting point.



Dolly's first uniform, the sailor suit of 1904. (Reproduced by permission of the Trustees of the Dolly Shepherd Pioneer Parachutist Archive and Ashby-de-la-Zouch Museum).



Dolly recuperating at Leigh Farm with the Hollins family after her near-fatal accident in 1908. (Reproduced by permission of the Trustees of the Dolly Shepherd Pioneer Parachutist Archive and Ashby-de-la-Zouch Museum).

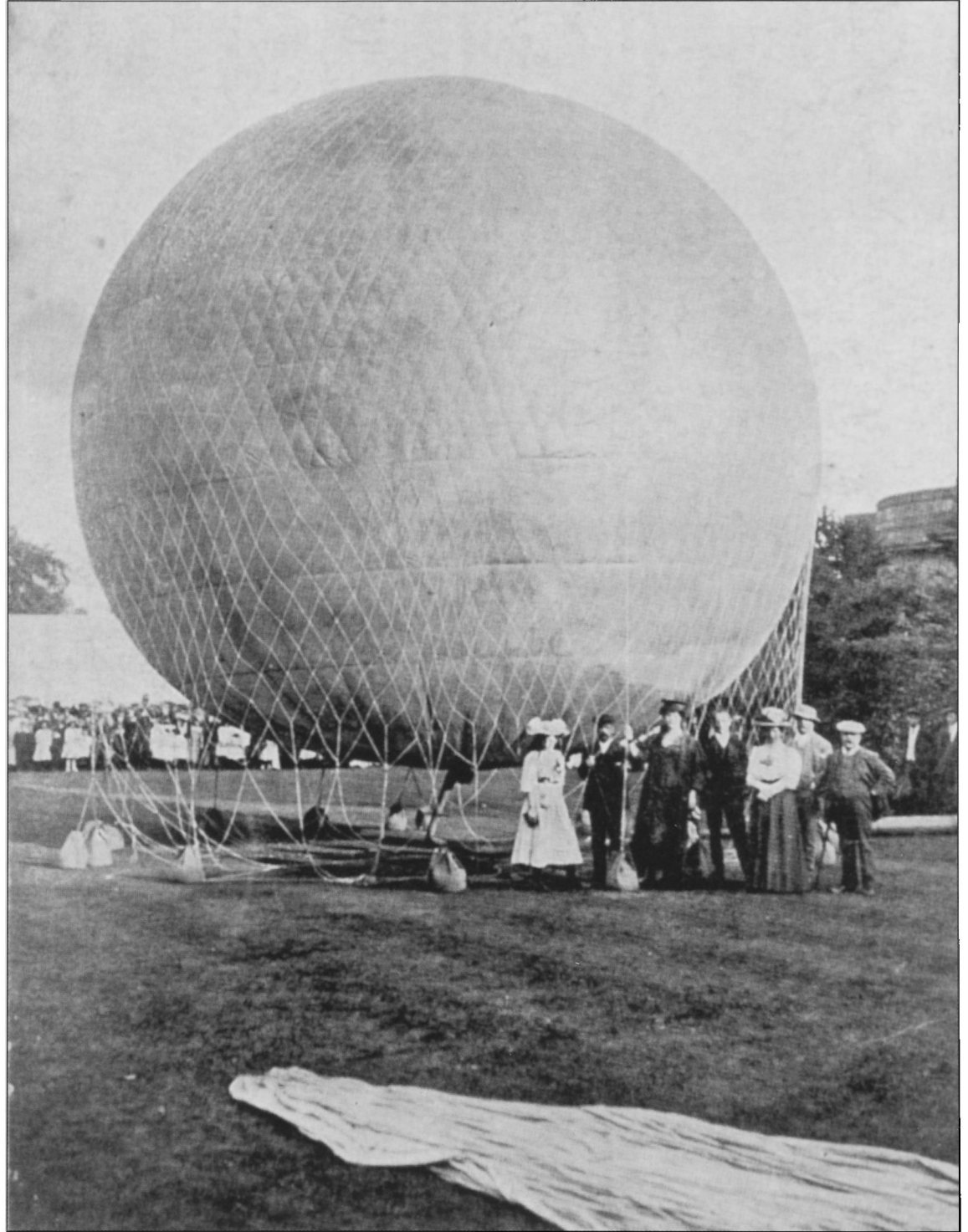
Following her appearance at the Ashby show in early August 1908 when she should still have been recovering from her ordeal above Longton, Dolly, 'an old favourite', went on to perform a double parachute descent at the Coalville and District Horticultural Society's tenth annual exhibition later that month. They alighted in the vicinity of Abbots Oak, where the two ladies were hospitably entertained by Mr Justice Joyce, 'and this accounted for the delay in their return'. On their tardy arrival at the showground, however, 'they received quite an ovation, and the Coalville Town Band struck up *See the conquering heroes* come. The natives of Coalville were not going to release Dolly as quickly as her ripping cord. They repeatedly questioned her about her marriage plans 'of which there had been persistent and circumstantial rumours'. Dolly laughingly replied that it was 'all rot' – the sons of the farmer who had looked after her at Longton, and who were prime suspects, were, in fact, 13 year-old twins. Dolly stayed in Coalville for over a fortnight, descending No. 2 pit at the Snibston Colliery, remarking that she 'enjoyed the novelty of going down instead of up very much'.

There were hazards a-plenty. The following year, the 11th annual exhibition of the Coalville and District Cottagers' Horticultural Society was held in the field off the Half-Way House Ground in August 1909. Fine weather may have favoured the event, but Dolly was soon to experience very different conditions. At 6.30 p.m. the balloon rose, Dolly waving her usual Union Jack at the upturned faces. At 4,000 feet she tugged on the ripping cord. Nothing happened. Several pulls later – still nothing. The pin had jammed in the release mechanism. Dolly would have to hang on until enough gas in the balloon had escaped through the neck of the bag to allow a descent. Looking up once more, to her horror Dolly saw that the flap had blown inside the neck of the balloon, virtually sealing it. With the cold increasing and with the aneroid now reading 12,000 feet, Dolly began to sing, shouting at the balloon 'Goodbye, Dolly, I must leave you'. The light faded. Dolly was through the clouds. Then there was nothing but blackness – just the moon. Then – strains of music. Dolly felt she was hallucinating. The music grew louder – it was a real band playing somewhere in the darkness below. A few minutes later, Dolly landed on terra firma. She let go of the bar and extracted herself from the sling. The balloon, relieved of her weight, disappeared into the night (to be found three days later, with the parachute still attached, in the North Sea). Within a mile, Dolly was knocking on the door of a cottage in Whissendine, north of Oakham. It was later estimated that she had drifted over 35 miles and had been clinging to the trapeze bar for well over three hours.

Once again in Coalville, at the end of August 1910, Dolly prepared for a double ascent with a Captain Eames. As the balloon rose, Dolly ran forward clutching the trapeze bar, expecting to be whisked swiftly and smoothly into the air. Cheers from the crowds suddenly turned to cries of horror: instead of soaring skywards, Dolly was dropping back to earth to crash land onto several bystanders. Not seriously hurt, Dolly managed to faint several times. One of the spectators, Mrs Bolton, wife of a vanman, was cut on the face through being accidentally kicked by Dolly and was carried unconscious to a nearby tent. The cords attaching the bar to the parachute canopy had been severed. It was never established whether this was by accident or by a more sinister reason.

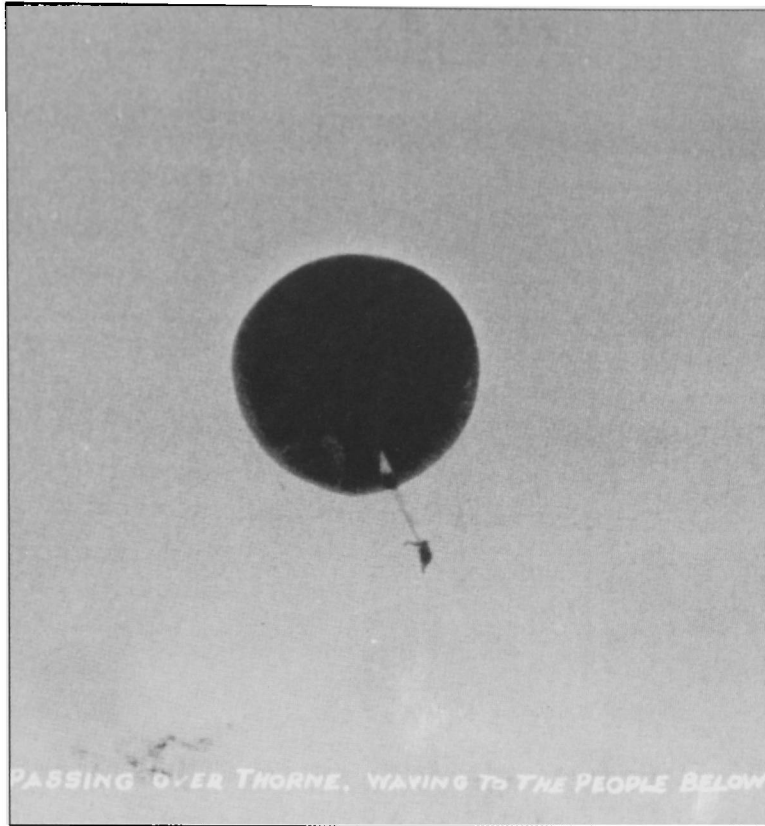
A more amusing, if embarrassing, incident occurred at Ashby. A windy day and a layer of low cloud meant that Dolly was unable to select a suitable landing spot with her usual accuracy. A few feet from the ground, the turbulence of the wind swung her backwards into a high barbed-wire fence. Impaled on the spikes, her feet still off the ground, holding on to the trapeze, Dolly realised with horror that the lower part of her uniform had been ripped from her waist and was hanging down below her knees. Unable to move, rescue only came in the guise of a young man, who had been walking in the nearby field. Sir Walter Raleigh would have been proud. The blushing youth managed to extricate Dolly from the fence and speedily took off his coat to form a screen behind which necessary adjustments could be made. By the time others had arrived Dolly was reasonably presentable. The episode remained a secret between Dolly and her Sir Galahad – one Bert Wilton. They met whenever Dolly came to Ashby and corresponded for many years afterwards.

Every so often members of the parachutist team Dolly belonged to ‘disappeared’. If their absence was remarked upon, the leader Captain Gaudron would merely say that they had ‘left the team’. They had – and this mortal coil. Dolly had had her scrapes, but continued to give shows until early 1912. One spring evening, high above Alexandra Palace, she clearly heard a voice. ‘Don’t come up again, or



At Ashby-de-la-Zouch in August 1908, Dolly's first ascent after her accident. (Reproduced by permission of the Trustees of the Dolly Shepherd Pioneer Parachutist Archive and Ashby-de-la-Zouch Museum).

you'll be killed.' She looked round at the empty sky. 'All right' she said out loud. Back safely on the ground, she gave her Union Jack to one bystander, her cap to another and her parachute badge to a third. She never parachuted again.



Dolly beneath a balloon, waving to the crowds below in 1911. (Reproduced by permission of the Trustees of the Dolly Shepherd Pioneer Parachutist Archive and Ashby-de-la-Zouch Museum).

Dolly served in the Women's Emergency Corps, later the Women's Voluntary Reserve, and then the WAACs during the Great War; in the Second World War she joined the Auxiliary Fire Service as a volunteer. At the age of ninety she flew with the Red Devils over Sussex. She was the guest of the RAF Falcons Parachute Display Team at Eastbourne Air Show in July 1983. She died on 21st September that year, only two months short of her 97th birthday.

Notes and References:

Ashby-de-la-Zouch Museum holds the *Dolly Shepherd Archive* of original memorabilia. The Museum has a small permanent display on her life as well as a life-size model of Dolly descending 'from the skies'.

If you wish to read more about Dolly Shepherd's remarkable life, look out for *When The 'Chute Went Up: Adventures of a Pioneer Lady Parachutist*, by Dolly Shepherd, with Peter Hearn and Molly Sedgwick (Skyline Publishing, 1996. ISBN 1874180016).

1. Source: Newspaper cutting in the Dolly Shepherd Archive, Ashby-de-la-Zouch Museum. Cut out by Dolly, and which has the hand-written date Tuesday 9th June 1908.



Aged ninety, Dolly meets the Red Devils and acts as 'co-pilot' in their Islander aircraft over Sussex. (Reproduced by permission of the Trustees of the Dolly Shepherd Pioneer Parachutist Archive and Ashby-de-la-Zouch Museum).